

Priesthood Of All Believers

doc-priesthood-of-all-believers
Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Every believer is a priest before God through Christ; there is no mediatorial priesthood between Christ and the believer beyond Christ Himself.

In plain language

The Greek group-word for priesthood, "priesthood" (hierateuma), appears only twice in the whole Bible, and the queried text confirms both times fall in First Peter chapter two, where it describes the entire body of believers. They are called a holy priesthood and a royal priesthood (basileion hierateuma), language taken straight from the promise in Exodus that all Israel would be a kingdom of priests (mamleket kohanim in Hebrew). Revelation says three times that Christ made the redeemed into priests (hierais), using the ordinary plural word for the whole company of the saved, and the word order shows priests standing right beside the word "us" (hemas), not naming a special class within the group. So at the level of vocabulary, the priestly title is spread across every believer rather than reserved for an office. On the second part of the claim, that no human priest stands between Christ and the believer, the words point the same way. First Timothy says there is one God and "one mediator" (heis mesites), and the numeral "one" (heis) rules out any additional go-between. Hebrews tells the brothers (adelphoi, the direct-address plural), in the plain plural, to draw near to God with boldness (parresia), using a verb for approaching (proserchomai) that once belonged to priests at the altar and now belongs to the whole "we." The only figure Hebrews names as a great priest (hieera megan) over God's house is Christ himself, who still lives to make intercession. There is one honest nuance to state plainly. These passages speak about worship and access for everyone; they do not, in these same words, settle whether the church also has a recognized ministry of teaching and oversight. That is a different question handled by different vocabulary, so the shared priesthood and a distinct teaching ministry are not actually in conflict at the level of these texts. The pattern holds across the Old Testament background, the letters, and the visions of Revelation, and no manuscript variant changes it. Taken together, the language affirms both halves: every believer is a priest, and the only mediating priest beyond that shared priesthood is Christ.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3548	כֹהֵן	kohen	priest	711
H4467	מַמְלָכָה	mamlakah	kingdom	117
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	
G0399	ἀναφέρω	anaphero	to carry up	10
G0749	ἀρχιερεύς	archiereus	high-priest	123
G0932	βασιλεία	basileia	kingdom	

G0934	βασίλειον	basileion	kingly	1
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	355
G2406	ιεράτευμα	hierateuma	priesthood	2
G2409	ιερεὺς	hiereus	priest	32
G2992	λαός	laos	a people	
G3316	μεσίτης	mesites	mediator	6
G3954	παρρησία	parresia	boldness	31
G4334	προσέρχομαι	proserchomai	to come near/agree	87

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The collective noun "priesthood" (hierateuma, G2406) occurs exactly twice in the canon, queried at 1 Peter 2:5 and 2:9, and both times it is predicated of the whole believing community with no priestly class standing between God and people in between. The plural "priests" (hiereis, G2409, parsed N-APM and N-NPM, accusative and nominative plural masculine forms) is predicated of the redeemed in Revelation 1:6, 5:10, and 20:6, standing in apposition (placed beside, naming the same group) to "us" (hemas) and "them" (autous), the entire company God made. 1 Timothy 2:5 fixes the mediator at "one mediator" (heis mesites), and the numeral "one" (heis) lexically excludes any additional human go-between. Hebrews uses the first-person plural urging form "let us draw near" (proserchometha, G4334, V-PNS-1P, a present subjunctive verb in the first-person plural, the "let us" form) and addresses "brothers" (adelphoi) in the vocative plural (the direct-address plural form), granting every believer "boldness" (parresia) to enter the holy places. The single mediating priest the text names beyond this shared priesthood is Christ as "high priest" (archiereus) and "great priest" (hierea megan).

Scripture

1Pet.2.5 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2406 ιεράτευμα, G0399 ἀναφέρω

Reasoning. Believers collectively, addressed as living stones being built up, become a "holy priesthood" (hierateuma hagion, G2406 parsed N-ASN, an accusative singular noun naming the whole group together). Their function is to "offer up" (anenenkai, from anaphero, G0399), spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. The priestly identity is predicated of the whole body of living stones, not of a distinct caste within it, and the sacrifices are mediated "through Jesus Christ" (dia Iesou Christou).

1Pet.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2406 ιεράτευμα, G0934 βασίλειον, G2992 λαός

Reasoning. The second and final canonical use of "priesthood" (hierateuma, G2406 parsed N-NSN, nominative singular naming the whole group) applies "royal priesthood" (basileion hierateuma) to the elect community, with "royal" (basileion, G0934) a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) occurring only here. The same plural subject "you" (Hymeis) is also called "chosen race" (genos eklekton), "holy nation" (ethnos hagion), and "people" (laos, G2992) for possession, fixing the priesthood on the entire people. This phrasing draws on the queried cross-reference to Exodus 19, the "kingdom of priests" promise.

Exod.19.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3548 כֹהֵן; H4467 מַמְלָכָה

Reasoning. The Hebrew source phrase "a kingdom of priests" (mamleket kohanim) predicates priestly status of all Israel corporately (as a single body, not subdivided), queried at Exodus 19:6 with "priest" (kohen, H3548) and "kingdom" (mamlakah, H4467) present in the verse. The whole people, not a sub-order, is addressed. 1 Peter 2:9 reapplies this corporate priestly identity to the believing community, so the same pattern spans Old Testament and New Testament.

Rev.1.6 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2409 ἱερεὺς, G0932 βασιλεία

Reasoning. Christ made the redeemed into a "kingdom" (basileian) and "priests" (hiereis, G2409 parsed N-APM, accusative plural masculine), to his God and Father. Token order confirms the plural "priests" (hiereis) stands in apposition (placed beside, naming the same group) to "us" (hemas) at word position three, so priestly status belongs to every member of the redeemed and not to a sub-order.

Rev.5.10 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2409 ἱερεὺς, G0932 βασιλεία

Reasoning. The redeemed from every tribe and tongue are made a "kingdom" (basileian) and "priests" (hiereis, G2409 parsed N-APM, accusative plural masculine) to God, and they reign on the earth. The accusative plural "priests" again maps onto the whole redeemed assembly, in apposition (placed beside, naming the same group) to "them" (autous), with no mediating sub-order introduced.

Rev.20.6 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2409 ἱερεὺς

Reasoning. Those in the first resurrection will be "priests of God and of Christ" (hiereis tou theou kai tou Christou, G2409 parsed N-NPM, nominative plural). This is the third predication of "priests" (hiereis) on believers, confirming the pattern that priestly status falls on the whole company of the blessed, who also reign with Christ.

1Tim.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3316 μεσίτης, G1520 εἷς

Reasoning. "For there is one God and one mediator between God and men" (Heis gar theos, heis kai mesites theou kai anthropon), the man Christ Jesus. The numeral "one" (heis, G1520, parsed A-NSM, nominative singular masculine adjective) governing "mediator" (mesites, G3316, parsed N-NSM, nominative singular masculine noun, the singular mediator) lexically excludes any additional mediatorial figure between God and people. "Mediator" (mesites) occurs six times in the canon and never names a class of human intermediaries.

Heb.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3954 παρρησία, G4334 προσέρχομαι

Reasoning. The first-person plural "let us draw near" form (proserchometha, G4334 parsed V-PNS-1P, a present subjunctive verb in the first-person plural, the "let us" form) with "with boldness" (meta parresias, G3954) urges all believers to approach the throne of grace boldly. The grammatical person is "we," the whole community, so the direct access is granted corporately and is not channeled through a human priestly intermediary.

Heb.10.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3954 παρρησία, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. Addressed to "brothers" (adelphoi, G0080 parsed N-VPM, vocative plural masculine, the direct-address plural form for "brothers"), the verse grants "boldness" (parresian, G3954) "for entry into the holy places" (eis ten eisodon ton hagion) by the blood of Jesus. The vocative plural shows the entry, formerly priest-only, is now extended to the whole congregation rather than a sub-order.

Heb.10.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4334 προσέρχομαι

Reasoning. The same first-person plural "let us draw near" form (proserchometha, G4334 parsed V-PNS-1P, present subjunctive first-person plural, the "let us" form) recurs: "let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith." The verb that once described priests approaching the altar is now predicated of the entire "we," with hearts sprinkled and bodies washed, confirming corporate direct access.

Heb.10.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2409 ἱερεύς

Reasoning. Having a "great priest over the house of God" (hierea megan epi ton oikon tou theou, G2409) names the single mediating priest as Christ over God's household. The one designated "great priest" beyond the common priesthood is Christ, so this verse fixes the only priestly intermediary on Christ and is consistent with the second half of the proposition.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Pet.2.9	Exod.19.5	tsk	1
1Pet.2.5	1Pet.2.9	tsk	1
Rev.5.10	Rev.1.6	tsk	1
Rev.5.10	Rev.20.6	tsk	1
1Pet.2.9	Deut.4.20	tsk	1
1Tim.2.5	Job.9.33	tsk	1
Heb.10.19	Heb.7.25	tsk	1
Heb.10.19	Heb.4.16	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Heb.4.14 · addressed

Christ is called "a great high priest" (archiereus megas), which could be read as instituting an ongoing high priestly office that competes with the common priesthood. The lexical force places this office on Christ alone, "who has passed through the heavens" (dielelythota tous ouranou), not on a continuing human order. "High priest" (archiereus) is queried at 123 occurrences, where the Gospels and Acts use it for the Jewish high priest and Hebrews predicates it of Christ, so the term confirms rather than competes with the believers' priesthood.

Heb.10.21 · addressed

The singular "great priest" (hierea megan) over the house of God again locates the mediating priest in Christ. No second human sacerdotal (priestly) tier is lexically introduced between Christ and the household, so the verse supports the proposition's exclusion clause.

Heb.7.25 · addressed

Christ always lives "to intercede" (entynchanein hyper auton, to make intercession on their behalf) for those who draw near, "those who are drawing near" (tous proserchomenous, G4334) through him to God. The continuing intercession is located in Christ alone and the access verb is the same one applied to all believers, so this confirms one ongoing mediating priest rather than a class of human mediators.

1Pet.2.5 · addressed

The believers' priesthood here is corporate worship and the offering of spiritual sacrifices, a different lexical category from the gifts of teaching and oversight named elsewhere. The vocabulary of "priesthood" (hierateuma) never excludes a distinct ministry of word and oversight, so the universal priesthood and a recognized teaching ministry are not lexically in conflict; the words simply do not address the latter in these texts.

Concordance traversed

G2406, G2409, G0749, G3316, G1520, G3954, G4334, G0934, G0399, G2992, H3548, H4467

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No VariantUnit nodes are populated in the lexical store for 1 Peter 2, Revelation 1, 5, and 20, Hebrews 4 and 10, or 1 Timothy 2, and none of these passages falls within published CBGM scope (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method scope, the published critical-edition window covers 3 John only), so this is ecm-shadow (outside the critical edition of New Testament textual variants window). The Majority and Received text reading at Revelation 1:6 and 5:10, "kings and priests" (basileis kai hierais), versus the critical reading, "a kingdom, priests" (basileian, hierais), is visible in the token sigla (the manuscript marker symbols), but the plural "priests" (hierais) is predicated of the whole redeemed under every plausible reading, so the verdict does not turn on any variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads 1 Peter 2:9 as the realization of the Exodus 19:6 "kingdom of priests" promise, with the one covenant people now corporately priestly, so every believer is a priest with direct access through the one mediator Christ.

dispensationalism: affirms · Locates the priesthood of all believers in the present church age and may reserve a distinct future temple economy, yet still affirms that within the church each believer is a priest with bold access secured by the single mediator named in 1 Timothy 2:5.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Sees the Aaronic order (the Old Testament priestly line descended from Aaron) fulfilled and ended in Christ's once-for-all high priesthood, under which the whole body shares the priestly access predicated by "priesthood" (hierateuma) and "draw near" (proserchomai), matching the lexical pattern.

corporate_priesthood_versus_ordained_ministry_distinction: affirms_with_scope_note · Reads the universal priesthood as corporate worship and direct access, a different lexical category from the gift of teaching and oversight described by other vocabulary. On this reading the universal priesthood does not by itself exclude a recognized teaching ministry, since "priesthood" (hierateuma) and "priests" (hierais) address worship and access, not church order. The proposition about priesthood and sole mediation still stands; the words simply leave the question of ordained ministry to other texts.

The verdict turns on the redemptive transfer from a restricted Levitical priesthood (the priestly line restricted to the tribe of Levi) to a corporate priesthood realized through Christ's high priestly work, hence redemptive-historical primacy (the method that reads each text in light of the unfolding plan of redemption across the whole Bible). All listed lenses converge on affirmation. The only genuine nuance, recorded in the fourth lens and in a complicating text, is that the universal priesthood (corporate worship and access) is a different lexical category from a distinct teaching or oversight ministry, and the two are not in conflict at the level of the words; there is therefore no cross-tradition divergence to flag on the proposition itself.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the New Testament lexically predicates priesthood of every believer and whether it institutes or excludes a distinct mediatorial priesthood between Christ and the believer.

The clause "there is no mediatorial priesthood between Christ and the believer beyond Christ Himself" encodes a negative conclusion within the stem (the question wording already presupposes the answer). The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form restates it as an open lexical question so the negation is not assumed. The terms "priesthood" (hierateuma), "priest" (hiereus), "high priest" (archiereus), and "mediator" (mesites) carry the evidentiary weight regardless of framing, and the queried data confirm them independently of the wording.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Pet.2.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Pet.2.9
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rev.1.6
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rev.5.10
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rev.20.6
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Heb.4.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Heb.10.19
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.19.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.2.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.10.19

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

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